The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

America's House of Representatives voted in favour of ending the national emergency that Donald Trump invoked to impose **tariffs** on **Canadian** imports last year. The measure now goes to the Senate, though the president will probably veto it if it reaches his desk. Still, the House vote is a symbolic rebuke of Mr Trump's trade policies, with six Republicans joining Democrats to support the resolution.

Police identified Jesse van Rootselaar, an 18-year-old transgender woman, as the suspected shooter in an attack on a school and nearby residence in the Canadian province of **British Columbia**. Nine people were killed in the shooting, including the attacker, who turned the gun on herself. Earlier authorities said that at least 25 other people were injured. A motive has yet to be confirmed.

Britain's economy grew by 0.1% in the fourth quarter of 2025, the same as the quarter before. The disappointing figure puts further pressure on Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's beleaguered prime minister, who had promised to kick-start the economy. Growth is not dreadful by European standards, but it is too meagre to give voters the living standards and public services they want.

Italy's government passed a bill authorising the use of naval blockades to stop migrants entering the country. The measure—championed by Giorgia Meloni, Italy's populist prime minister—would be rolled out when there is a surge of migrants attempting to reach the country's shores. Earlier this week European Union lawmakers approved new measures to counter illegal immigration, including swifter repatriation.

Following a meeting with **Binyamin Netanyahu** in Washington, **Mr Trump** said "nothing definitive" was decided about dealing with Iran's nuclear programme, but that negotiations with the Islamic Republic would continue. Earlier, during a speech to mark the 47th anniversary of the Islamic revolution, Iran's president said he was prepared to allow nuclear inspections, and reiterated that the country was not building an atomic weapon.

Pershing Square, a hedge fund run by **Bill Ackman**, an activist investor, disclosed a stake in **Meta** worth around 10% of the fund's capital. Mr Ackman said investors' fears about Meta's heavy spending on AI had undervalued the company, and that it stands to benefit from the technology. Earlier Meta announced that it had begun construction on a $10bn data centre in Indiana.

Kraft Heinz paused plans to split into two companies. The struggling American food giant originally announced in September that it would break up its slow-growing store brands from its seasonings and sauces business. Steve Cahillane, Kraft Heinz's new boss, said the company's problems were "fixable" and would instead invest $600m to beef up its marketing efforts and product offerings.

Figure of the day: 99%, Brazil's gross public debt as a percentage of its GDP, up from 62% in 2010. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

A democratic milestone in Bangladesh

On Thursday people in Bangladesh began voting in the country's first general election since Gen-Z protesters toppled Sheikh Hasina Wajed, the despotic prime minister, 18 months ago. It is the first competitive poll since the one that elected Sheikh Hasina in 2008. Two parties with long histories are going head to head: Jamaat-e-Islami, the largest and most moderate of Bangladesh's Islamist groups, and the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, led by Tarique Rahman, whose late mother and father both governed Bangladesh. Some of the student activists who helped throw out Sheikh Hasina are also running for seats in parliament.

Many voters are disappointed that Bangladesh's upheaval has not empowered new parties with bold and innovative agendas. The Islamists are probably less tolerant than they make out; the BNP's previous stints in power were marred by corruption. Still, Bangladesh has come a long way since its recent revolution.

Photograph: Reuters

Mixed tidings from Ukraine

Ukraine's new defence minister, Mykhailo Fedorov (pictured), will be bearing both bad and good news for his country's allies at the Ukraine Defence Contact Group which gathers in Brussels on Thursday. Mr Fedorov, a 35-year-old former tech entrepreneur, will make a desperate plea for more missile-defence interceptors. Russia has exploited the shortage by pummelling Ukraine's energy infrastructure with ballistic missiles, sometimes firing 30 in a salvo.

However, Russia also appears to be suffering a sharp rise in battlefield casualties for miniscule territory gains. Last year Russian forces advanced between 15 and 70 metres on average a day. As Michael Kofman, an American military analyst, puts it: "they are trading previous losses in equipment for much higher losses in personnel." He argues that even with its superior manpower and huge signing-on bonuses, Russia will eventually run out of "individuals for whom the money is worth it." That should poke some holes in Vladimir Putin's narrative of inevitable Russian victory.

Photograph: Reuters

The EU's old economic problems—and old solutions

Leaders of the European Union's 27 national governments will gather in a chateau in eastern Belgium on Thursday to brainstorm ways to enliven the bloc's listless economy. Concerns that Europe is falling behind America, and failing to keep up with Chinese innovation, are not new. But they have intensified of late because of Trumpian tariffs and European companies' insecure access to critical raw materials from China.

Leaders will discuss plans to make the single market work better for companies that want to do business across EU borders. One idea is to launch a new form of company, known as EU Inc, to enable entrepreneurs to seamlessly reach the EU's 450m consumers. France is promoting "buy-European" rules to give domestic suppliers priority when governments buy goods and services, especially in defence, digital and industrial sectors. But other countries, such as Sweden, denounce that idea as old-fashioned protectionism.

Illustration: David Simonds

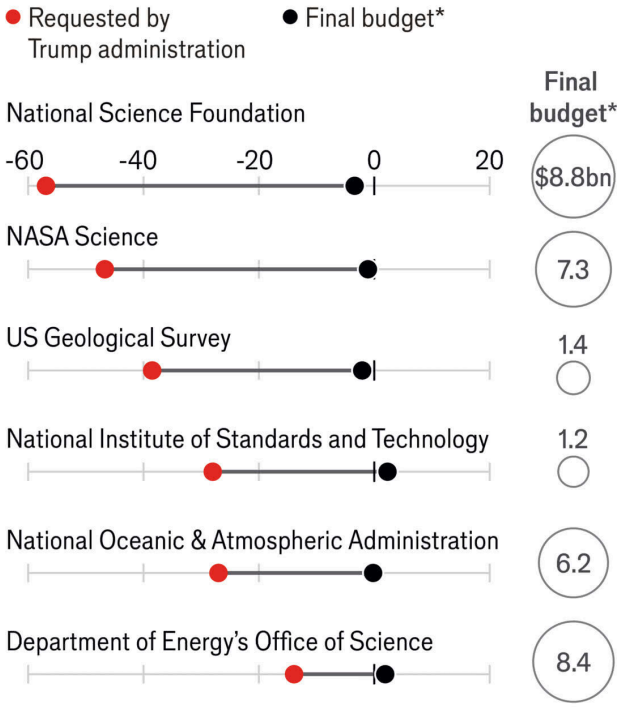
Science under siege in America

As the American Association for the Advancement of Science gathers in Phoenix, Arizona, on Thursday for its annual meeting, scientific matters will be jostling for attention with political ones. The complacent confidence with which scientists in America once viewed government support for their endeavours, regardless of who occupied the White House, has been shaken by an administration that dismisses and distrusts academia.

The Trump administration ignores the data in areas such as climatology. It cannot see the point of fields, such as planetary science, that are driven by curiosity rather than practical value. It has appointed a health secretary who seems to regard vaccines as the spawn of the devil rather than one of medicine's finest achievements. Though bipartisan support for science still exists in Congress, which recently pushed back on several proposed funding cuts, the mood at the AAAS is likely to be gloomy, as researchers discuss how to weather the storm.

Holding the line

US, budget proposals for selected science agencies, FY 2026, % change on year earlier



*After compromises between the House and Senate
Source: American Institute of Physics

Photograph: Virginie Surdej

The riches of Berlinale

The 76th International Berlin Film Festival opens on Thursday with “No Good Men”, an international co-production between Afghanistan, Germany, France, Norway and Denmark. Directed by Shahrbanoo Sadat, a young Afghan film-maker, it sheds light on the lives of women in her home country which she left in 2021 for Germany. Ms Sadat also plays the lead role of Naru, the only female camera-operator at Kabul TV, whose blossoming acquaintance with Quodrat, a reporter (played by Anwar Hashimi), changes her mind about Afghan men—just before the Taliban’s return.

More than 200 films, selected from 8,000 submissions, will follow with screenings across many of the festival’s cinemas until February 22nd. The competition’s line-up spans genres from satirical comedy to psychological thriller, and features “A New Dawn” a Japanese-French animation and “Yo (Love is a Rebellious Bird)”, an American documentary on love between an old and a young woman. The jury, headed by Wim Wenders, a German film-maker, as well as viewers are in for a treat.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of the UK?

The abstract kills, the concrete saves.

Sylvia Plath